

THE TROIKA Raoul Kerr, Karan Katiyar and Jayant Bhadula are currently on a world tour

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MUSIC ▼

MUSIC WITH A MESSAGE

Heavy metal band Bloodywood's second album is dedicated to their home city, Delhi

Heavy metal has a niche following within India, but New Delhi band Bloodywood's take on the genre—which blends in hip-hop and Indian folk music rendered in a mix of Hindi and English and occasionally Punjabi—has won fans around the globe. The trio of composer and multi-instrumentalist Karan Katiyar, singer Jayant Bhadula and rapper Raoul Kerr is currently on a world tour in support of their recently-released second album *NU DELHI*.

The record, which is dedicated to their home city and features 'Bekhauf', a collaboration with Japan's BABYMETAL, is their first since signing to American label Fearless Records on whose roster they're the only Indian act. The 2024 signing was another among Bloodywood's long list of achievements that includes playing almost every major metal festival in the world and cracking the US and UK album sales charts with their debut collection *Rakshak* (2022) on the back of a fan campaign.

A highlight was "performing to nearly 60,000 people at [the] Download [festival in England] in 2023", says Bhadula. It was a special moment for the group that started out in the mid-2010s as an internet sensation. Back then, Bloodywood—Bhadula clarified that the name was not inspired by the title of Mumbai electro-rock band Pentagram's 2011 album—was best known for their headbang-friendly versions of Bollywood and pop hits such as Bombay Rockers' 2005 smash 'Ari Ari' and the title track of *Rang De Basanti* (2006).

THE ALBUM, WHICH ALSO FEATURES A COLLABORATION WITH JAPAN'S BABYMETAL, IS THEIR FIRST SINCE SIGNING TO AMERICAN LABEL FEARLESS RECORDS

But it wasn't until they completed their first tour of Europe and the UK in 2019 and performed their original material to packed crowds that they "knew we belong", says Kerr. A sense of belonging is also what bonds their fans, which they've been told by multiple venue staff in India, Germany and the US, are some of the most "wholesome" they've encountered. Says Kerr, "Our music is a place for everyone to come together."

A big reason for this is that in Bloodywood's case, the moshing is accompanied by a message. 'Dana-Dan'—which was synched in the Dev Patel-directed movie *Monkey Man* (2024)—confronts sexual violence; 'Gaddar' decries political communalism; 'Jee Veerey' addresses depression; 'Hutt' takes on trolls; and 'Daggebaaz' is a scathing comment on corrupt corporations. ■

—Amit Gurbaxani